Russia back in the '90s: no expansion eastward—this was stated publicly. Since then, several waves of expansion took place, culminating with Ukraine being drawn into NATO. This completely displeases us and poses a serious threat. Let's remember that NATO is a military-political alliance, and Article 5 of the Washington Treaty establishing NATO hasn't been repealed. It's a threat to us. Nobody bothers to take us seriously. Lastly, when Ukraine became independent, few people recall this: what was the first document ratifying independence? It was the Declaration of State Sovereignty, Independence of Ukraine. That forms the foundation of Ukrainian sovereignty and modern statehood. And it clearly states that Ukraine is a neutral state.

Q. Do you want to go back to being a part of the G8?
A. No. The fact of the matter is that at a certain point I stopped attending those meetings. This is the first point. The second thing is that as I have said before, it's not entirely clear why the countries that form the G7 call themselves the 'Big Seven'? What's so big about them? In terms of purchasing power parity, India's economy is the third largest in the world. And where are countries like the United Kingdom in terms of purchasing power parity? What is their ranking now, tenth or thereabouts? Of course, these are all countries with advanced, high-tech economies; a robust foundation exists, it hasn't gone anywhere, although their share in the global economy is shrinking year after year. The trend is obvious, and it will keep going like that, as far as can be seen, among other things, due to what I would cautiously call the deeply flawed economic policies pursued by the leadership of many of those countries. A recession in Germany is evident, for the third year in a row; France is in a difficult situation, also on the brink of recession, as are other leading European nations. Nevertheless, it is an important platform; they do work there, they do make decisions, they do discuss matters among themselves, and so may they all be healthy by God's grace. However, there's another aspect here. Look at the current relationship between Russia and European countries. These relationships are far from being called normal. How do you imagine that I come to the G8 meeting, how would I talk to its members if they don't want to talk to me? What am I supposed to do there then? But other major international alliances are forming now—such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO), BRICS, and the G20. We're involved everywhere, and we have a completely non-confrontational approach.

Q. Is the world order changing? Who do you see as a new power centre in the multipolar world?
A. The world changes and evolves constantly. Nowadays, this rate of change is fast, indeed very high. We can see it, we can feel it. And primarily, we're witnessing the global economic processes unfolding. These processes aren't linked to events in Ukraine or other hotspots, but they're just happening generally. One fact remains, however: new centres of growth—of rapid, strong growth—are emerging. These include countries of the Global South, notably South Asia, India and Indonesia, which alone has nearly 300 million people and is rising quickly. Let me say it again: Africa is already advancing swiftly and will accelerate even more. With its young population, these countries would be our future. They'll strive toward higher living standards, which is inevitable. In the future, rates of change in the global economy will continue to accelerate steadily and significantly.

"Trump pursues his own policy. His decisions aren't made from thin air. He has advisors who believe implementing tariffs ultimately benefits the US economy"

Q. How do you have these alternative blocs and how can they become a real force, if there are fundamental unresolved issues between key member-states in that bloc?
A. You know, conflicts always exist. Tell me in what period of history was there no conflict at all? The point is elsewhere: it's about finding solutions to these conflicts, seeking most